were driven from their home by another clan, the Taichi'ut, who hoped to gain the khanship of their tribe; the exiles spent the next years scrounging for food in the cold wastes of the Khentil mountain range. Temujin was later captured by the Taichi'ut clan chief and escaped, still wearing the wooden collar used to confine him. By the time he turned sixteen, he was an adult with fully fledged instincts for survival.[3]

Now old enough to be considered the head of his clan, Temujin revisited the home of his betrothed bride, Borte, and insisted that her father honor the arrangement. He then approached the khan of the nearby Kerait tribe and negotiated an alliance. The khan, an experienced middle-aged soldier named Toghrul, had been a friend of Temujin's dead father; but he was more impressed with the gifts Temujin brought than with the obligations of that old attachment.

Almost immediately, Temujin was forced to call on both of his new allies for help. Another three-tribe coalition, known collectively as the Merkit, invaded his camp while he was away and kidnapped Borte.

Kidnapping was the second most popular way for a Mongol to get a wife; Temujin's own mother had been kidnapped, decades before, from a Merkit tribesman, and the raid was both revenge and an attempt to check Temjuin's growing power. It backfired. Temujin, Toghrul, and Temujin's childhood friend Jamuqa joined forces (perhaps ten thousand horsemen, converging on the Merkit camp) and wiped the Merkit out. *The Secret History* celebrates the victory with song:

> . . . [W]e tore their livers to pieces.
> We emptied their beds
> And we exterminated their relatives;
> The women of theirs who remained,
> We surely took captive!
> Thus we destroyed the Merkit people.[4]

(Borte was rescued as well, an event that gets much less space in *The Secret History* than the victory in battle.)

A series of other victories followed. Temujin's star was rising, and by 1200 or so he expected to be elected Great Khan, the warleader of the entire Mongol confederation. Instead, in 1201—the Year of the Hen in the Mongol calendar—his opponents banded together to throw their weight behind Jamuqa.

This was the end of the friendship between the two men. As children, they had sworn a blood-brothers oath of loyalty; now they were enemies. Between